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TIES THAT BIND: PALM WINE AND BLOOD-BROTHERHOOD AT THE KENYA COAST DURING THE 19TH CENTURY

Thomas J. Herlehy

It is time to broaden our approach to the study of African history. For much of the last twenty years Africa's past has been discussed often by focusing only on the local history of particular ethnic groups. Now there exist enough local histories to draw upon that we can begin to write the history of Africa from a more regional perspective. Indeed, Thomas Spear suggests that we take such an approach in examining the history of Kenya during the precolonial era.¹ One region in particular for which there is a considerable body of literature is the Kenya coast. Building upon foundations established by previous studies, this article will discuss the economic and social ties that bound the peoples of the Kenya coast together during the nineteenth century. In particular this is a case study of the economic link created by the demand for palm wine and other commodities, and the social cohesion sustained by blood-brotherhood and intermarriage among the Mijikenda peoples and their neighbors, the Swahili, Arabs, Waata (Sanye or Ariangulo), Orma (Galla), Akamba, and Taita.

Previous studies of the Kenya coast have emphasized that there was a shift in regional trading patterns after 1837 when the Busaidi took control of Mombasa. These scholars argue that as the Akamba and Swahili merchants began to engage in long-distance trade, the importance of Mijikenda brokers in such regional commerce declined.² However, there is some evidence which suggests that although the Mijikenda lost their predominant position in long-distance trade, many Mijikenda entrepreneurs continued to participate actively in regional commerce until the late nineteenth century. Furthermore, the pivotal role which the Mijikenda occupied in local patterns of commerce, upon which long-distance trade depended, never really diminished until the mid-twentieth century. Indeed, increasing specialization among some coastal residents made them even more dependent on local and regional trade after 1840 or 1850 than they

¹Thomas Spear, *Kenya's Past: An Introduction to Historical Method in Africa* (London, 1981).

²Fred J. Berg, "The Coast From the Portugese Invasion," *Zamani*, ed. by B.A. Ogot, 2nd ed., (Nairobi, 1974), 132-133; Thomas T. Spear, *The Kaya Complex: A History of the Mijikenda Peoples of the Kenya Coast to 1900* (Nairobi, 1978), 137-138, 145.

might have been in 1800. This is certainly true of the Mijikenda living around Rabai who developed an economy unique in East African history, becoming a palm wine exporting and food importing people during the nineteenth century.

The coastal region under consideration consists of three geographical zones, each with a distinct ecology. The coast itself and its immediate hinterland form one zone, characterized by relatively good rainfall (35-55 inches per annum), with sandy soil suitable for fruit trees and cereal crops. Swahili and Arab planters, fishermen, and traders inhabit this area. The hinterland, home of the Mijikenda, is a transitional ecological zone.³ The hills overlooking the coast enjoy moderate rainfall and the sandy soil is conducive to the cultivation of fruit trees, especially the coconut palm, as well as vegetables and grains. However, just beyond these hills the rainfall decreases and the environment is less suitable for agriculture and more conducive to pastoralism. The third geographic area can be referred to as the coastal fringe, which consists of two separate ecological zones: the dry Taru Desert inhabited by Waata hunters and gatherers, and Orma pastoralists, and the well-watered Taita Hills and Ukambani plateau populated by Taita, and Akamba farmers, herders, hunters, and traders.

By the beginning of the nineteenth century the peoples living within these different ecological zones formed an informal regional unit integrated by trade. The basis for this regional economy was the desire of these economic specialists to procure each other's products. On the local level, there was extensive trade among the Mijikenda peoples of the coastal hinterland, and among the Waata, Orma, Akamba, and Taita of the coastal fringe. On a regional level all of these peoples participated in the creation and extension of economic networks which coalesced their respective economies into a more comprehensive unit. This increased economic unity was complemented by the forging of social bonds, especially through the pledging of blood-brotherhood and intermarriage.

Within the coastal region there are two overlapping patterns of trade which involved different kinds of goods: those produced and consumed domestically, and those destined for export. Products circulating primarily within the domestic economy were exchanged between neighboring peoples who sought to increase the variety of goods available for consumption, and included foodstuffs, household goods, and some prestige items. During the nineteenth century, for example, palm wine was produced in the region of Rabai, but it was traded and consumed throughout the entire coastal region. Yet palm wine was never exported to Zanzibar or other overseas markets. On the other

³The Mijikenda are composed of "nine closely related but distinct peoples who share a common linguistic and cultural heritage." The vernacular designations for the nine peoples are the AChonyi, ADigo, ADuruma, AGirama, ADzihana or AJibana, AKambe, AKauma, ARawai, and ARIhe. Names for the nine Mijikenda peoples are usually given without the plural prefix "A" but the prefix is retained here in order to distinguish the indigenous inhabitants from the place names associated with their home territory. Mijikenda itself is a KiSwahili term derived from the vernacular *Midzi Chenda* ("nine villages") and is rendered Miji Kenda by some writers, including those of coastal origin. Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 4-44.

hand, export commodities tended to be traded over longer distances and they were not consumed very widely within the coastal region itself. These goods were primarily raw materials and luxury items such as copal, rhino horn, and ivory, although some cereals and livestock were exported from the coast as well.

This article is concerned primarily with the local trade of items produced and consumed within the coastal region itself. Although there were some subtle changes in the direction and operation of this domestically oriented trade, for the most part the links within the regional economy remained fairly constant throughout the nineteenth century. Essentially it was the existence of these local trading networks which integrated the different peoples and ecological zones of the coast into a regional unit and made possible the existence of long distance trade. By focusing on the trade in one item which was consumed extensively throughout the coastal region, such as palm wine, one can illustrate how economic specialists were able to acquire and enjoy the wide range of commodities which were available within the region.

There are several institutions which create inter-ethnic links within the coast as well as other parts of Kenya and the rest of Africa, and act to coalesce the peoples of an area into a social unit. Islam was one such link because people who shared the same religion tended to cooperate in other matters, including trade. Inter-marriage was another method used to foster social unity. One important social link which was used throughout Africa and especially in the Kenya coastal region was blood-brotherhood. Anthropologists have devoted some attention to the study of blood-brotherhood in Africa, but few historians have discussed this important institution.⁴ One notable exception is Cordell's analysis of the role of blood-partnership in the expansion of Muslim influence in the central Sudan.⁵ Cordell illustrates how certain Muslims used pacts of blood-brotherhood to gain political and economic power among the non-Muslim Banda people living around Dar al-Kuti during the late nineteenth and early twentieth century. Blood-brotherhood in the Sudan and in the Kenya coast had economic and social functions which were often complimentary and mutually reinforcing. For example, blood-brotherhood could be used by commercial partners to routinize and secure their trading relations, while the kinship links created by the bonds of blood-brotherhood could be used by local merchants to increase the extent of their commercial activity over a large territory. During the nineteenth century traders from different parts of the Kenya coast bound themselves to each other by swearing oaths of blood-brotherhood. By examining the social links created by these ties in tandem with the economic links provided by local trade we can gain a better understanding of the institutional links which foster the cohesion of regional socio-economic units.

⁴T.O. Beidelman, "Blood Covenant and the Concept of Blood in Ukaguru," *Africa*, XXXIII (1963), 321-342; and E.E. Evans-Pritchard, "Zande Blood-Brotherhood," *Africa*, VI (1933), 369-401.

⁵Dennis D. Cordell, "Blood Partnership in Theory and Practice: The Expansion of Muslim Power in Dar Al-Kuti," *Journal of African History*, 20 (1979), 379-394.

Palm Wine and the Coastal Economy

At the center of the coastal region, both geographically and economically, were the Mijikenda peoples. Although they produced and sold a variety of products, the most popular commodity which they traded was palm wine, or *uchi*.⁶ During the entire nineteenth century, the ARavai people living around Rabai were the premier cultivators and tappers of the coconut palm tree and they dominated the commerce in palm wine.⁷ The demand for *uchi* and other coconut palm products such as coconuts, copra, and *makuti* thatching made Rabai the vortex of local and regional networks of trade. The ARavai sold palm wine to their Mijikenda neighbors, especially the ADuruma, AGiriama, ARihe, and AKambe, and to the Akamba, Taita, and Waata traders who brought their own vegetables, grain, livestock, and other commodities to sell in Rabai. Swahili and Arab merchants and, later in the century, Indian traders came to buy coconuts and copra from the Mijikenda, too. These entrepreneurs frequently formalized their trading relationships by becoming nominal kin through the pledging of blood-brotherhood. It was not uncommon for the more successful traders to marry into the host community, too, further strengthening their relations with their trading partners. Indeed, it was the existence of these local networks of kinship and trade among neighboring peoples which facilitated the expansion of regional trade and ensured the success of long-distance caravan trade in Kenya.

Although the coconut palm tree has grown along the East African coast for many centuries, it did not spread into the hinterland until fairly recently. Among the Mijikenda, the ADigo seem to have been the first to cultivate the coconut tree, adopting it sometime in the seventeenth century.⁸ The ARavai maintain that they were the first to plant coconut palms after getting the seed from the coast near Jomvu or Changamwe in the mid-eighteenth century.⁹ Once

⁶*Uchi* is the local term used by the Mijikenda to refer to palm wine, whereas *tembo* is the word used by Swahili speakers. J.L. Krapf and J. Rebman, *A Nika-English Dictionary*, ed. by T.H. Sparshott (London, 1867), 363 and J.L. Krapf, "Journal, 1847-49," CMS: CA5/0/16/171, (Church Missionary Society archives, University of Birmingham, England).

⁷The ARavai are also known as the Rabai and Arahai. To avoid confusion between the place, Rabai, and the inhabitants of Rabai and Ruruma locations I will refer to the people as the ARavai, which is the name they use to refer to themselves.

⁸Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, xxi, 4.

⁹Thomas J. Herlehy, "Coconut Palm Traditions," (CPT) interviews with the Mijikenda, CPT 3: Figo Dzogofya, *kaya* elder (Rabai) March, 1980, CPT 4: Nzaka Kunya, *kaya* elder (Rabai) March, 1980, CPT 6: Gaya Begaya, *kaya* elder (Rabai) April, 1980. Transcripts of these traditions are in the author's possession and will be deposited at Boston University and the University of Nairobi. I would like to acknowledge the generous support of the Fulbright-Hays Research Program which enabled me to carry out the fieldwork for my forthcoming Ph.D. thesis.

the coconut palm reached Rabai, it did not spread as rapidly to the rest of the Mijikenda as it did among the ARavai themselves. The ARIhe and AKambe began to cultivate coconut trees by the early and mid-nineteenth century, while the AChonyi, AJibana, and AKauma adopted them a bit later.¹⁰ The ADuruma and the AGiriama were the last Mijikenda to plant coconut trees on a wide scale sometime in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.¹¹ Even the Taita tried to cultivate coconut palms during the mid and late nineteenth century, however, the ecological environment there was not very suitable.¹² In 1914 Rabai still had more coconut palms than any other Mijikenda locale, with some 87,757 trees, while the next largest concentration was in Ribe, with about 20,437 palms.¹³

This lapse in the adoption of the coconut palm tree seems to indicate that the Swahili and Arabs of the coast, and later the ADigo themselves, tried to monopolize the production of coconut palm products, including uchi, by not allowing the coconut seed to fall into the hands of other coastal peoples. The ARavai testify that once they did get the coconut seed, its dissemination was strictly controlled by the *kaya* elders and only the elders or their blood-brothers were allowed to plant it.¹⁴ This may explain why the coconut palm spread fairly rapidly among the ARavai themselves but did not spread so quickly to the other Mijikenda. It also suggests that there was some economic specialization among the Mijikenda with the ADigo and the ARavai acknowledged as the skilled palm wine tappers and traders while the ADuruma, AGiriama, and AKambe were primarily grain or vegetable farmers, or stock herders.

The pace and the direction of the dissemination of the coconut palm was undoubtedly affected by ecological constraints as well. The coastal strip from Vanga in the south to Kilifi in the north possesses the right mix of sandy soil and moderate rainfall for coconut cultivation as do areas around Malindi and Lamu. Within the coastal hinterland, Rabai and Ruruma locations have the most suitable ecology in which the coconut palm can thrive. Farther west towards Maria-kani there is less rain and farther north towards some parts of Kambe there is more clay soil which makes coconut cultivation less

¹⁰Herlehy, CPT 5: Bahari Gude, Chonyi trader (Rabai) April, 1980, CPT 44: Mulinge Mgala and Ambale Bugo, *kaya* elders (Ribe) October, 1980, CPT 45: Mwayayi Mturi and Daniel Katana, farmers (Kambe) October, 1980; J. Rebmann correspondence of May 2, 1863, OMS: CA5/0/24/42; Thomas Wakefield correspondence, *United Methodist Free Churches* (UMFC) magazine, 8 (1865), 68; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, xxi, 4, 92-94.

¹¹Cynthia Brantley, "Giriama Historical Traditions," (GHT), GHT 17: Nzaro wa Chai, 1971, GHT 23: Masha wa Kalumba, 1971, GHT 55: Thuva wa Kijambo, 1971, transcripts available at the University of Nairobi, History Department library; David Parkin, *Palms, Wine and Witnesses* (San Francisco, 1972), 17-18, 49, 65.

¹²C.W. Hobley, "Upon a Visit to Tsavo and the Taita Highlands," *Geographical Journal*, v. 6 (June, 1895), 554-555; E. Hollis Merritt, "A History of the Taita of Kenya to 1900" (Ph.D. thesis, Indiana University, 1975), 188.

¹³Kenya National Archives, Coast Province, Minute Paper 115, "Report of a Commission to Consider the Question of the Improvement of the Coconut Industry," 1913-1914, documents: letter from J.M. Pearson, Assistant District Commissioner (Rabai) to the Commission, 8 May 1914.

¹⁴Herlehy, CPT 1: Garero Mwawara, farmer (Rabai) February, 1980, CPT 3: Figo Dzugofya, CPT 11: Dagamra Shaha, farmer (Rabai) May, 1980, CPT 12: Bedzuya Mrenje, *mganga* (Rabai) May, 1980.

feasible. Consequently it is not uncommon to find AKambe and ARIhe farmers who do not plant coconut trees and who do not know how to tap them, whereas it is quite rare to find any ARavai farmers who are not growing coconut palms or who cannot tap them.¹⁵

The Mijikenda desire for local sources of uchi was certainly the most important reason for their adoption of coconut palm cultivation. During the nineteenth century, palm wine was a beverage consumed by Mijikenda elders on all ritual and social occasions. Gifts of palm wine were an integral part of marriage negotiations and were part of the bridewealth itself. The payment of uchi was of special importance because it guaranteed the husband ownership of the generational rights over his wife - that is, any children born would stay with him if he and his wife ever divorced.¹⁶ This payment varied from as few as two *kadzama* (calabashes) to as many as twenty *kadzama* of uchi.¹⁷ Palm wine was used as an ancestral offering, too, being placed in a coconut shell and put on the grave of one's forefathers. Compensation paid for criminal offenses or social misconduct included payment of at least one calabash of uchi, as well.¹⁸ Furthermore, applicants seeking to join the kaya council of elders or any secret societies were required to donate palm wine to members of those groups as part of their initiation fee.¹⁹ Although palm wine did not have such comparable importance within the cultural complex of Akamba, Taita, Waata, or Orma rituals and institutions, they still sought it because uchi was a beverage to be enjoyed and a commodity to be sold back in their own home areas.

Local Patterns of Trade During the Early Nineteenth Century

During the eighteenth century most Mijikenda went to the coast or Digo land to buy uchi for their own use.²⁰ Indeed, this trade in palm wine may have been one of the earliest economic links between the coast and its hinterland, and it endured even after the

¹⁵Among 64 ARavai farmers interviewed, all of them owned coconut trees, whereas one of 18 ARIbe farmers and 3 of 15 AKambe farmers interviewed had not planted any coconut trees, Herlehy, CPT.

¹⁶Herlehy, CPT 1: Garero Mwawara, CPT 2: Jindwa Dzuya, Farmer (Rabai) February, 1980; John W. Hanford, correspondence of March, 1879, CMS: CA5/0/11/31.

¹⁷A *kadzama* holds about 20-25 quarts of uchi. Regarding bridewealth payments, see W.E.H. Barrett, "Notes on the Customs and Beliefs of the Wa-Giriana, etc., British East Africa," *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute*, 41 (1911), 20; L.P. Cerlach, "The Social Organisation of the Digo of Kenya" (Ph.D. thesis, University of London, 1960), 81-86; Herlehy, CPT 5: Tsama Mkuzi, *kaya* elder (Rabai) April, 1980.

¹⁸Herlehy, CPT 1: Garero Mwawara, CPT 4: Nzaka Kunya, CPT 7: Nzaka Ngao, *kaya* elder (Rabai) April, 1980.

¹⁹The *kaya* is the original settlement of the Mijikenda peoples within the coastal region, and each people have their own central *kaya* where the elders meet to conduct rituals and decide matters affecting the welfare of the local community. Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 1, 6-7, 44-65; Herlehy, CPT 3: Figo Dzogofya, CPT 4: Nzaka Kunya, CPT 31: Shongwe Kombo and Dzomba Ndune, *kaya* elders (Ruruma) September, 1980, and CPT 46: Chiringa Mwatela, *kaya* elder (Kambe) October, 1980.

²⁰Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 4, 66, 85; Herlehy, CPT 45: Mwayayi Mturi and Daniel Katana, CPT 46: Ziro Mchombo and Chiringa Mwatela, *kaya* elders (Kambe) October, 1980.

Mijikenda began to cultivate their own coconut palm trees. Although most Muslim planters of the coast abstained from palm wine themselves, they still collected and sold it to anyone else who wanted to drink it.²¹ Boteler noted that the Mijikenda who came to Mombasa to sell ivory and rhino horn in the 1820s usually spent some of their profits on uchi to celebrate the end of another successful trading expedition.²² And in the 1840s, Krapf observed that some Mijikenda still were going to Mombasa to buy palm wine.²³

While this particular pattern of trade in uchi persisted throughout the nineteenth century, it tended to diminish in importance at the coast itself. There were two reasons for this. Arab and Swahili planters around Mombasa became more interested in increasing their production of coconuts and copra in order to meet the rising international demand for vegetable oils. And the Mijikenda themselves began cultivating coconut palms on a wider scale which enabled them to produce, consume, and trade their own supplies of uchi. Because only one product can be harvested from the coconut tree at any one time, whether it be coconuts or uchi, the coastal planters' preoccupation with coconut and copra production ensured that the Mijikenda producers of palm wine would face no serious competition from the coast itself for the duration of the nineteenth century.²⁴

Palm wine was only one of the many commodities traded between the Mijikenda and their Swahili and Arab neighbors. Indeed, several writers have commented that the relationship between the coast and Mijikenda was one of economic interdependence, especially while the Mazrui ruled Mombasa and the rest of the coast before 1837.²⁵ In years of surplus production, Mijikenda farmers sold grains and vegetables to Mombasa, and in times of famine Mombasa imported foodstuffs from other regions of the Indian Ocean and sold that food to the Mijikenda. Among the products which the Mijikenda sold to the Swahili and Arabs were sorghum, millet, maize, sesame, tobacco, copal, and timber. In return, the Mijikenda bought fish, salt, calico and cotton cloth, jewelry, hardware, and other manufactured goods.²⁶

²¹J.L. Krapf, letter of 25 September 1844, CMS: CA5/0/16/28.

²²Thomas Boteler, *Narrative of a Voyage of Discovery to Africa and Arabia* (London, 1835), II, 212-213.

²³J.L. Krapf, letter of 2 September 1844, CMS: CA5/0/16/27 and 25 September 1844, CMS: CA5/0/16/28.

²⁴Only one product can be harvested from the coconut palm tree because the branch which bears the coconut fruit is the same branch which is tapped for palm wine. If the fruit bearing branch of the tree is tied up and cut at the tip every day so that the palm sap can flow, the branch will not bear any coconuts. Coconuts can only grow on those branches which are left untapped.

²⁵Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 71-72. 92-95; Fred J. Berg, "Mombasa Under the Busaidi Sultanate: The City and Its Hinterland in the 19th Century" (Ph.D. thesis, University of Wisconsin, 1971), 88-89, 249; C.S. Nicholls, *The Swahili Coast: Politics, Diplomacy and Trade on the East African Littoral, 1798-1856* (New York, 1971), 57.

²⁶Boteler, *Narrative of a Voyage*, v. 2, 17, 23, 178, 205-208; J.B. Emery, "A Journal of the British Establishment of Mombasa from 1824 to 1826," Adm. 52/3940 (Admiralty Archives, Public Record Office, London); C. Guillian, *Documents Sur L'Histoire, La Géographie et le Commerce de L'Afrique Orientale* (Paris, 1856), II, 382.

Just as the ARavai were the premier producers of palm wine, so too did each of their neighbors have their own speciality. By the beginning of the nineteenth century the ADigo already had well established trading relations with the Vumba, Akamba, and other Mijikenda peoples. The ADigo sold palm wine to ADuruma and ARIhe in return for grain. Swahili and Arab merchants bought grain, coconuts, sesame, and copal and sold the ADigo fish, cloth, beads, and wire. The Vumba purchased mangrove timber, mats, spices, and baskets from the ADigo and sold them clay pottery. The ADigo also learned rice cultivation from the Vumba during this era.²⁷

The ADigo were prominent regional traders during the early nineteenth century, organizing expeditions inland to buy goods for themselves and for resale at the coast. Before ca. 1830, ADigo merchants went to Ukambani to buy cattle and ivory in exchange for cloth, beads and wire. The ADigo may have gone as far as the Pare Hills to buy cattle or slaves there.²⁸ ADigo merchants sold cattle and ivory to their Swahili and Arab counterparts in markets known as *chete* which were held every four days near the coast.

Most other Mijikenda peoples had similar local trading contacts with their neighbors during this period. The ARIhe and AKambe sold grain to the ARavai for uchi even after they began to cultivate their own palm trees.²⁹ Swahili merchants also bought grain from the ARIhe and AKambe. Copal and rubber were sold by the AKambe, AKauma, and AJibana to coastal buyers.³⁰ The AJibana also specialized in the manufacture of clay pottery which they sold to their Mijikenda neighbors. Rain-making was the speciality of the AChonyi and the other Mijikenda relied upon them for this service.³¹ Grain, copal, and rubber were sold by the AChonyi in coastal markets as well.

The ADuruma, like the ADigo, enjoyed both local and long-distance trading relations. On a local level the ADuruma sold sorghum, gourds, maize, millet, cowpeas, beans, and green gram to the ARavai for palm wine. The ADuruma also sold cereals and copal directly to Swahili and Arab traders at Changamwe. On a regional level, the ADuruma acted as brokers for Akamba cattle herders, selling Akamba cattle at Changamwe, too. Through this cattle trade with their Akamba neighbors, the ADuruma themselves acquired so much cattle of their own that they gradually changed from being a primarily agricultural people to a primarily pastoral people by the end of the nineteenth century.³²

²⁷William F. McKay, "A Precolonial History of the Southern Kenya Coast" (Ph.D. thesis, Boston University, 1975), 165-173; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 85-86.

²⁸A.C. Hollis, "Nyika Proverbs," *Journal of the African Society*, 16, 61 (1916), 67; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 85-86.

²⁹J.L. Krapf, "Journal, 1845," CMS: CA5/0/16/167; A.D. Shaw, "A Journal of a Trip in Giriama," (1882), CMS Archives; Herlehy, CPT 45: Mwayayi Mturi and Daniel Katana, CPT 47: Chai Munga and Ngala Chai, *kaya* elders (Ribe) October, 1890.

³⁰Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 92-94.

³¹*Ibid.*, 69.

³²*Ibid.*, 88.

The AGiriama were very active traders throughout the nineteenth century. Because they lived in a transitional zone between good farmland and pasture, the AGiriama were both farmers and cattle herders. AGiriama grain farmers bought palm wine in Rabai and sold their own cereals in Mombasa. The AGiriama engaged in local trade with their Waata neighbors buying wild animal skins and meat, and ivory and rhino horn in exchange for grain and cloth. However, on a regional level, some of these same goods, especially ivory and rhino horn, were then sold by the AGiriama to the Arabs and Swahili. In the early nineteenth century, the AGiriama also acted as middlemen between the Akamba and the coast itself. AGiriama traders traveled to Ukambani where they bought cattle for themselves, for resale to their Mijikenda neighbors, or for sale to the Arabs and Swahili along the coast.

Many of the goods which the Mijikenda consumed or traded came from the coastal fringe, from the Akamba, Waata, Taita, and Orma peoples. The Waata of the Taru Desert hunted rhino, elephant, giraffe, eland, zebra, buffalo, ostrich, waterbuck, impala, and gazelle. They sold the skins and dried meat from these animals as well as ivory and rhino horn to their Mijikenda neighbors in exchange for uchi, grain, cloth, and beads.³³ The Waata also traded these products with the Taita and Orma and received vegetables, cereals, and livestock from them. The Orma were active in local and long-distance commerce, too. J.L. Krapf met Orma traders at Takaungu in 1844 selling ivory and cattle there.³⁴ The Orma also traded with the Pokomo, and AGiriama. Although the Orma did engage in peaceful commerce, they still posed a military threat to their neighbors in the early and mid-nineteenth century. In order for combatants to engage in peaceful commerce, there had to be an institutional mechanism whereby they could pledge mutual trust and guarantee the safety of each others' traders. Blood-brotherhood was used by the Orma and their neighbors to forge such bonds.

The Taita engaged in local commerce with the Mijikenda. However, Taita relations with some of their neighbors were characterized by hostility as well as reciprocal cooperation, and the former often exceeded the latter.³⁵ It was for this reason that traders traveling to Taita land became blood-brothers with local merchants and elders. When relations were peaceful, Taita entrepreneurs came to Rabai to buy palm wine in exchange for grains, vegetables, and meat. Taita merchants also sold ivory and rhino horn to the Mijikenda in exchange for cloth, jewelry, and hardware.³⁶ Some Taita even travelled to Jomvu, another ARavai market near Mombasa, to sell cattle, gum copal, ivory, and rhino horn directly to Swahili and Arab traders there. Yet the patterns of trade which merchants followed were more involved than a simple exchange between specialists, as explained by some Taita traders:

³³Herlehy, CPT 4: Nzaka Kunya, CPT 14: Mfuko Mpee, *kaya* elder (Rabai) June, 1980; C.W. Hobley, "The WaLangulo or Ariangulo of the Taru Desert," *Man*, XII, 9 (1912), 18-21; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 89-91.

³⁴J.L. Krapf, *Travels, Researches and Missionary Labours During an Eighteen Years' Residence in Eastern Africa*, 2nd ed. (London, 1968), 115.

³⁵Merritt, "History of the Taita," 148.

³⁶*Ibid.*, 169-173; Boteler, *Narrative of a Voyage*, II, 205-206.

We used to take calabashes to the Giriama people. They gave us maize for them which we sold to the Rabai people. In payment for the maize the Rabai people gave us local liquor. We took the liquor back to the Giriama people and sold it to them for cloth. Then we returned to Sagalla and traded the cloth for more calabashes, goats and cattle which we took to the coast.³⁷

These trading relations between the Taita and the ARavai and other Mijikenda must have been well established by the early nineteenth century because both Krapf and Rebmann were impressed by the ability of their ARavai guides to translate and converse with the Taita in the 1840s.³⁸

The Akamba were major trading partners of the Mijikenda and other coastal peoples, too. During the early nineteenth century, Mijikenda merchants traveled to Ukambani where they bought cattle and ivory and sold uchi, cereals, vegetables, spices, cloth, beads, and jewelry.³⁹ The Akamba also made expeditions of their own to trading centers like Rabai. Because of a series of famines and droughts in Ukambani from 1790 through 1836, the Akamba were migrating towards the coast and settling in places such as Samburu and Mariakani.⁴⁰ These settlements became entrepôts for Akamba long-distance caravans which began to reach the coast in the 1830s, enabling Akamba to bypass some local Mijikenda middlemen in many of their trading transactions.

Until the 1840s the Mijikenda were firmly at the center of the coastal regional economy. They played an integral role in the local trade of domestic commodities, supplying one of the most popular items within the region, palm wine. The Mijikenda also occupied a middleman position in the network of trade which carried most import and export goods between the coast and the interior. After the 1840s, the Mijikenda gradually lost their middleman role in the regional commercial system. But the pivotal role which Mijikenda farmers and merchants played in the domestic economy and local net-

³⁷Testimony of Mwakina, Mwazola, Mwalimo and Mwagono, collected by E. Hollis Merritt, cited in "History of the Taita," 172.

³⁸Krapf, *Travels*, 178-179; J. Rebmann, "Journal of a Journey, 1848-49," CMS: CA5/0/24/53.

³⁹Herlehy, CPT 1: Garero Mwawara, CPT 3: Figo Dzugofya, CPT 10: Ambari Washe, *kaya* elder (Rabai) May, 1980, CPT 13: Bemunga Abdallah, farmer (Rabai) June 1980, CPT 24: Harry Fanjo, ex-chief (Rabai) July 1980.

⁴⁰Krapf, *Travels*, 142-143; Krapf, "Journal, 1845," CMS: CA5/0/16/167; Robert J. Cummings, "Aspects of Human Portage with Special Reference to the Akamba of Kenya: Towards an Economic History" (Ph.D. thesis, University of California, Los Angeles, 1975), 58, 169-170; Kennell A. Jackson, Jr., "An Ethnohistorical Study of the Oral Traditions of the Akamba of Kenya" (Ph.D. thesis, University of California, Los Angeles, 1972), 221, 231-233, 299.

⁴¹Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 88; Frederick Cooper, *Plantation Slavery on the East Coast of Africa* (New Haven, 1977), 99; Berg, "Mombasa Under the Busaidi Sultanate," 107-108; Nicholls, *The Swahili Coast*, 311.

works of trade remained constant throughout the nineteenth century. Uchi especially remained a product which was in constant demand, even during famines, and this ensured that Rabai would retain its importance in the local networks of trade which continued to unite the coastal region throughout the nineteenth century.

Competition in an Era of Change, ca. 1837-1900

The mid and late nineteenth century is a significant period of political change within the coastal region. During this era, the Busaidi drove the Mazrui from Mombasa in 1837 and took control of the Kenya coast, with the exception of the Mazrui refuge at Takaungu. Although it is easy to overemphasize the significance of this change in rulers at the coast as it affected the whole coastal region, there is still no doubt that the Busaidi attached less importance to maintaining good relations with their Mijikenda neighbors than the Mazrui did.⁴¹ This had some obvious economic implications. When the Busaidi rulers betrayed Mijikenda trust by selling the people whom the Mijikenda had mortgaged at the coast in order to get food during the Maere famine of 1837, the Mijikenda retaliated by shifting much of their commerce with the coast away from Mombasa to Takaungu or Jomvu.⁴² Although official Busaidi policy manifested little interest in including the Mijikenda in the operation of the coastal political economy, individual Swahili and Arab families, who had been dealing with the Mijikenda for many years, continued to maintain their socio-economic ties with them. This ensured that some level of amicable contact was sustained between Mombasa and its hinterland for the duration of the nineteenth century. For example, when Krapf arrived in Mombasa in 1844, he met Mijikenda traders who were there on business. And it was a Muslim trader from the coast, Abdallah bin Pisila, who escorted Krapf to Rabai in 1845.⁴³ In 1857, when Richard Burton came to visit Krapf and Rabmann, he was taken from Mombasa to Rabai by Muslim residents of Mombasa as well.⁴⁴

It was also during this era that the British became involved in the affairs of the Kenya coastal region, both directly and indirectly. British missionaries established stations throughout the coast beginning in the 1840s, and British merchants arrived in Mombasa by the 1880s when the Imperial British East Africa Company obtained a concession to trade in the area. Finally the whole region became a British Protectorate in 1895. Yet even these new forces did not dramatically affect the operation of the local economy during the period under consideration. Rather, the British impact was felt more on Zanzibar itself and by those merchants involved in overseas commerce, particularly the slave trade. It would not be until the

⁴²Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 83, 137-138; Cooper, *Plantation Slavery*, 128-129; Peter L. Koffsky, "History of Takaungu, East Africa, 1830-1896" (Ph.D. thesis, University of Wisconsin, 1977), 50-66.

⁴³Krapf, *Travels*, 24, 119-120, 128, 131, 135-150.

⁴⁴Richard F. Burton, *Zanzibar: City, Island and Coast* (London, 1872), II, 45-54.

twentieth century that the British would exert any substantive influence over the domestic economy of the Kenyan coastal region.

This is an era of some economic significance because of the changes in the regional pattern of export and import trade. The Akamba in the 1830s, and the Arabs and Swahili in the 1850s and 1860s, began to organize their own long-distance caravans to transport and trade goods between the coast and the interior, thereby effectively eliminating most Mijikenda from their role as middlemen in the export/import trade.⁴⁵ Because of this competition, the Mijikenda had to carve out new roles for themselves as guides, porters, and partners of Akamba, Arab, or Swahili caravans. A few entrepreneurs among the Mijikenda did continue to engage in long-distance trade, but these men were the exception.⁴⁶ Nzaka Fondo of Rabai travelled to Taita land where he bought ivory during the 1850s and 1860s. Mlangi Mtsunga of Rabai also traded ivory which he purchased from the Waata for resale to Mombasa during the 1850s and 1860s. Mfuko Mruu also bought ivory from the Waata, and later he joined Arab expeditions to Ukambani during the late nineteenth century in order to purchase additional ivory. Kava Mulumbi of Rabai worked on several Swahili expeditions that went as far as Uganda in the 1860s and 1870s, and after travelling as a porter he became a trader in his own right. Kavu continued to lead expeditions to Ukambani and other parts of Kenya until the late nineteenth century when he retired in relative comfort in Rabai. Kinda Mumvondi and Paul Fanjo were two other ARavai traders who organized their own expeditions to Ukambani to purchase cattle during the 1880s and 1890s.⁴⁷ The ARavai and the AGiriama were the most successful Mijikenda brokers to make this adjustment during the era of competition.⁴⁸ Their unique position between Mombasa and the interior and their long-standing relationships with Akamba, Taita, and Waata hunters, and farmers enabled them to continue to be active in regional trade until very late in the century when they were overwhelmed by the influx of more wealthy Arab, Swahili, and European traders.⁴⁹ For example, in 1857 some Mijikenda merchants were still going to Mombasa and Jomvu where they sold copal, ivory, hippopotamus teeth, rhinoceros horn, cattle, and cereals such as rice, maize, and millet.⁵⁰ But by 1868, this pattern of trade began to change as

⁴⁵McKay, "Precolonial History," 177-178; Cummings, "Aspects of Human Portage," 57, 99-109, 150-151, 214-220; Jackson, "Ethnohistorical Study," 219-221.

⁴⁶Cullain, *Documents*, II, 279-280; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 116-120; Herlehy, CPT 10: Ambari Washe, CPT 14: Mfuko Mpee, CPT 26: Dzuya Kavu, farmer (Maji ya Chumvi) July 1980.

⁴⁷Herlehy, CPT 4: Nzaka Kunya, CPT 10: Ambari Washe, CPT 14: Mfuko Mpee, CPT 26: Dzuya Kavu, CPT 37: Uthman Kinda, ex-Chief (Ruruma) September 1980, CPT 24: Harry Fanjo; Charles New, *Life, Wanderings and Labours in East Africa* (London, 1873), 115.

⁴⁸New, *Life and Labours*, 115; Berg, "Mombasa Under the Busaidi," 107-108, 226; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 116-121.

⁴⁹Herlehy, CPT 10: Ambari Washe, CPT 11: Dagamra Shaha, CPT 13: Bemunga Abdallah, ex-sub Chief (Rabai) May 1980, CPT 30: Gideon Mkando, ex-Chief (Ruruma) September 1980, CPT 37: Uthman Kinda, CPT 47: Chai Munga and Simba Sadaka, farmers (Ribe) November 1980; Richard F. Burton, *Zanzibar: City, Island and Coast*, II (London, 1872), 67; Guillain, *Documents Sur L'Histoire*, II, 279-280; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 88-92, 96-97, 116-120, 136-138.

⁵⁰Burton, *Zanzibar*, II, 45, 67; New, *Life and Labours*, 55.

Swahili and Arab traders from the coast went directly to Mijikenda, Akamba, and Taita farmers to buy cattle, goats, sheep, grains, and coconuts, while selling shrimp, shark meat, seafood, cloth, jewelry, and hardware.⁵¹

On the local level the Mijikenda continued to enjoy fruitful trade among themselves and with their neighbors. The local trade of domestically produced and consumed commodities continued virtually uninterrupted throughout the nineteenth century. Akamba, Taita, Waata, AGiriama, and ADuruma traders came to Rabai to sell their grains, vegetables, meat, and livestock in order to buy palm wine from the ARavai. Within the domestic economy this was a significant era for the uchi industry. Gradually, the ARavai lost their monopolistic position in the palm wine trade as ARIhe, AKambe, and AChonyi neighbors began to cultivate and tap their own coconut trees. By 1900 virtually all Mijikenda peoples were cultivating some coconut palms. Yet although the ARIhe and AChonyi began to compete with ARavai uchi merchants, the ARavai retained their preeminent position within the palm wine industry. The ARavai cultivated and tapped the greatest number of coconut trees and the wide availability of palm wine in Rabai continued to attract customers. The ARavai were recognized as the most skilled palm tappers throughout the whole coastal region and even when their neighbors began to cultivate their own trees it was the ARavai who taught them how to tap.⁵² Indeed, the ARavai often migrated to other areas within the coast to work as palm wine tappers on a permanent basis, a trend which has continued until the present time.⁵³ Furthermore, the ARavai formed extensive socio-economic relationships with their customers which kept both buyers and sellers together during this era of competition. These factors ensured that the ARavai would dominate the uchi trade throughout the nineteenth century despite the beginning of competition from their coconut palm growing neighbors.

It was during this era that ARavai specialization in the uchi industry reached its zenith. The ARavai brought so much land under coconut palm cultivation that they ceased to be an agriculturally self-sufficient people and became a food-importing group instead. This trend was first observed by J. Rebmann in the 1860s and commented on again by H.K. Binns in the 1870s.⁵⁴ Binns wrote that it was easier for the ARavai to procure goats and grain by selling uchi to their Akamba neighbors than it was for them to cultivate maize themselves.⁵⁵ At the end of the nineteenth century, F. Lugard wrote somewhat critically of this phenomenon:

⁵¹Herlehy, CPT 3: Figo Dzogofya; Thomas H. Sparshott correspondence of 21 November 1868, CMS: CA5/0/26/4; New, *Life and Labours*, 124-125.

⁵²Herlehy, CPT 44: Mulinge Mgala and Ambale Bugo, *kaya* elders (Ribe) October 1980, CPT 45: James Mwachai, farmer (Kambe) October 1980.

⁵³Herlehy, CPT 1: Garero Mwawara, CPT 4: Nzaka Kunya, CPT 11: Dagamra Shaha, CPT 17: Tsuma Mumba, *kaya* elder (Rabai) June 1980, CPT 38: Mwitwa wa Tabia, farmer (Ruruma) September 1980, CPT 43: Wesa Mwambawa, *kaya* elder (Rabai) September 1980.

⁵⁴J. Rebmann, correspondence of 2 May 1863, CMS: CA5/0/24/42.

⁵⁵H.K. Binns, correspondence of 29 September 1879, CMS: CA5/0/3/11.

The owners of trees in Rabai can make so lucrative a trade in the sale of *tembo* in exchange for grain brought by the Giriama - that the result is that they are too lazy to do any work whatever in their fields - their wants are supplied in exchange for tapping the trees.... The purchasers are not only coast natives but the WaTaita and other tribes of the interior. Long strings of men may be seen from morning till night on the paths leading to the coast, each with three enormous gourds full of grain for exchange for *tembo*.⁵⁶

There were other changes within the domestic economy of the coastal region during this period. The Orma gradually withdrew north across the Sabaki River enabling AGiriama farmers to continue their northward expansion.⁵⁷ Mijikenda farmers began to export grains through Malindi which itself emerged as a grain-exporting area in the 1860s and 1870s.⁵⁸ Furthermore Taita, Akamba, and Mijikenda farmers could sell foodstuffs to the long-distance caravans which traversed their territories during this period. Indeed there was a certain level of mutual interdependence between the caravans and local villages. Caravan leaders relied on the local people to provide labor as porters, to sell them food, and to provide the export goods which they sought. In return, these villages received a share of the import commodities brought by the long-distance traders. And both the villagers and caravan leaders depended on each other to restrain from raiding one another. This often necessitated the swearing of blood-brotherhood between the caravan leaders and local notables, a phenomenon we will now consider.

Social Cohesion Within the Coastal Region: Blood-Brotherhood

Lest a distorted image be perpetuated, it is important to note that the coastal region was not just characterized by harmonious, symbiotic trading relations among the local inhabitants. Indeed, the coast often was torn with warfare and raids conducted by the Orma, Maasai (Kwavi), Taita, Akamba, Arabs, and Mijikenda against each other. Neighbors robbed, kidnapped, and killed each other with a relative amount of frequency during the nineteenth century. Because of these constant dangers which travelers and traders encountered, there was a need for a system whereby strangers could trust one another and guarantee the protection of anyone engaged in peaceful commerce. Blood-brotherhood and intermarriage were the most widely used methods to ensure the socio-economic cooperation of different groups of people, guaranteeing the mutual safety of merchants moving from one area of the coastal region to another.

Blood-brotherhood (*kurya tsoga*) is a fairly common institution in Africa and it was especially popular within the Kenyan coastal region during the nineteenth century. Swahili traders and politicians became blood-brothers with their Mijikenda neighbors and their

⁵⁶Frederick Lugard papers, "Memorandum on the Means of Checking the Sale of Native Liquor" (1892) mss., British Empire S39, Rhodes House Library, Oxford University.

⁵⁷Berg, "Mombasa Under the Busaidi," 259-260; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 110-114; Cynthia Brantley, *The Giriama and Colonial Resistance in Kenya, 1800-1920* (Berkeley, 1982).

⁵⁸Cooper, *Plantation Slavery*, 81-85.

long-distance trading partners among the Akamba and Taita. Mijikenda traders themselves pledged blood-brotherhood with one another which fostered intra-Mijikenda unity. Some Mijikenda merchants also became blood-brothers with the Taita, Orma, Waata, and Akamba. The Taita and Akamba used blood-brotherhood to maintain good relations between one another, too. Indeed, blood-brotherhood was such a respected institution in the area that even some of the early European travelers and colonial administrators had to become blood-brothers with local residents before they could expect an hospitable reception by host communities.

The ceremony in which two individuals pledge blood-brotherhood is virtually the same throughout the entire Kenya coastal region. First a chicken or goat must be slaughtered and cooked. The individuals wishing to become blood-brothers then take a piece of the roasted meat, and rub it in a cut which has been made in their own chests so that the meat mixes with their own blood. Next these individuals exchange and eat the meat while swearing an oath of brotherhood and loyalty to each other. The essence of this oath is that the pledgors commit themselves to treat each other like "real brothers," with love and trust, and that if either one tries to harm the other in any way, then he will die for having broken his oath. This ceremony is witnessed by any kin of the participants who live in the area, and any village or clan elders who can attend. In this way these men become nominal kin in each others' eyes and in the eyes of the whole community.⁵⁹

By pledging to be blood-brothers, individuals create social bonds linking themselves, their families, and their descendants together. From that moment, whenever one of them visits the village of the other that visitor is no longer a stranger to be feared but is accepted as someone with their own local identity, as a member of a local lineage or clan in the host community. This guarantees that the visitor will be received hospitably by the local residents of the host community, with the local blood-brother accepting full responsibility for his guest's behavior. This guaranteed the host community that someone from within the local area would ensure that local rules were not transgressed by the visitor.⁶⁰

Blood-brotherhood has economic as well as social significance. Because many people would not trade with strangers until they became blood-brothers, trade became a socio-economic enterprise conducted by nominal kin. Entrepreneurs used blood-brotherhood to enhance existing business relationships. By swearing an oath of mutual brotherhood, both buyers and sellers could ensure that they would be able to procure and sell their commodities in times of economic scarcity or intense competition, because blood-brothers gave first preference to their nominal kin in any business transaction. In this respect, trade and blood-brotherhood were mutually reinforcing mechanisms creating social and economic cohesion among the many peoples of the coastal region.

Among the most prominent people pledging blood-brotherhood during the nineteenth century were the Mijikenda. Blood-brotherhood provided the culturally similar Mijikenda peoples with an important

⁵⁹Testimony of Dennis R. Ngenja Swafi (Rabai); Herlehy, CPT 26: Dzuya Kavu; J.W.T. Allen, ed., *The Customs of the Swahili People* (Berkeley, 1981), 167-168; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 69; Spear, *Kenya's Past*, 115.

⁶⁰Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 69; Spear, *Kenya's Past*, 115.

social link with each other. The most notable Mijikenda groups swearing blood-brotherhood were the ARavai and the AGiriama which is a reflection of the active role they played in local and long-distance trading networks. ARavai individuals pledged blood-brotherhood with their AKauma, AChonyi, ARIhe, AGiriama, and ADuruma counterparts.⁶¹ Some ARIhe and AKambe farmers became blood-brothers with the ADuruma, too.⁶² A few ARIhe traders also swore blood-brotherhood with AChonyi, AGiriama, and AJibana merchants, too.⁶³ Indeed, most of these individuals who pledged blood brotherhood were traders seeking to gain entry to or solidify their position in a host community where they bought or sold commodities. For example, when the AKauma, AChonyi, ARIhe, AGiriama, or ADuruma merchants came to Rabai to buy uchi, they first sought out their own blood-brothers in order to be sure of getting all the uchi they wanted. Today many of their sons and grandsons are following this same pattern, maintaining the relationships which were first established during the nineteenth century.

The Mijikenda became blood-brothers with the Akamba, Taita, Orma, Waata, and the Swahili which increased the socio-economic unity of the coastal region. Traders from Rabai, Ribe, Kambe, and Giriama went to Ukambani to buy cattle and they pledged blood-brotherhood with local traders in Kitui and Machakos.⁶⁴ Often these blood-brothers would give each others names to their own sons which might be seen as an aspect of nascent cultural unity.⁶⁵ AGiriama and ARavai relations with the Waata were based on blood-brotherhood, too.⁶⁶ The Orma and AGiriama also swore oaths of loyalty and friendship when they became trading partners.⁶⁷ The Taita used blood-brotherhood as a cross-lineage link among themselves much as the Mijikenda did, and the Taita also swore blood-brotherhood with Akamba traders. In fact, any caravan leader who came to the Taita Hills had to seek out a local notable with whom he could swear blood brotherhood in order to be assured safe passage through the area and access to local goods.⁶⁸

Relations between the Mijikenda and the Swahili peoples of the coast were based on ties of blood-brotherhood, too. The AGiriama are

⁶¹Herlehy, CPT 22: Mwayambi Mwazuma, farmer (Rabai) July 1980, CPT 5: Tsama Mkuzi, CPT 44: Chirere Dzombo, *kaya* elder (Ribe) October 1980, CPT 18: Bemwamba Dena, farmer (Rabai) June 1980, CPT 16: Madziwe Saha, farmer (Rabai) June 1980.

⁶²Herlehy, CPT 46: Samson Bajila Baya, farmer (Kambe) October 1980, CPT 47: Ngala Chai.

⁶³Herlehy, CPT 48: Karisa Chai, *kaya* elder (Ribe) November 1980.

⁶⁴Herlehy, CPT 15: Kailo Mzuka, farmer (Rabai) May 1980, CPT 18: Bemwamba Dena, CPT 26: Dzuya wa Kavuu, CPT 43: Wesa Mwambawa, CPT 45: Daniel Katana, CPT 47: Ngala Chai; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 58, 90, 97, 125.

⁶⁵Herlehy, CPT 44: Mulinge Mgala reports that his own name is a local version of the name of the Akamba trader with whom his father became blood-brothers, Mulinga.

⁶⁶Herlehy, CPT 16: Madziwe Saha; Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 31, 117, 125; Spear, *Kenya's Past*, 50.

⁶⁷Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 69-70, 117, 125; Spear, *Kenya's Past*, 115.

⁶⁸Merritt, "History of the Taita," 87-88, 155, 214.

known to have had blood-brothers among the Swahili traders of Mtsan-ganyiko as well as among the Mazrui politicians and merchants of Takaungu.⁶⁹ It may be that even the special relationship which each Mijikenda people had with the twelve Swahili bribes of Mombasa during the Mazrui era was based, at least partially, on mutual oaths of blood-brotherhood.⁷⁰ These ties between the Swahilis and Mijikenda did not lapse during the Busaidi era either. As noted above, when Krapf asked in 1844 if he could travel among the Mijikenda, the Mombasa residents mentioned that it would be safe as long as he was accompanied by a Swahili guide who could use his own contacts to ease Krapf's entry into the local community. Swahili individuals played a similar intermediary role up and down the coast throughout this era, and this must have been based on their ties of nominal and real kinship with the inhabitants of the coastal hinterland.⁷¹

Even the first European explorers and administrators in Kenya had to become blood-brothers with the local people in order to be able to move about freely and safely. F. Lugard became the blood-brother of several Akamba men when he traveled through Ukambani in the 1890s.⁷² C.C. von der Decken had to swear an oath of blood-brotherhood with the Taita in 1861 after his own caravan was threatened with attack.⁷³ When C.W. Hobley arrived to administer Taita land in 1892 he became blood-brother with a local elder, too.⁷⁴ Further inland Delamere was traveling among the Embu in 1899 but he was unable to procure supplies for his caravan from the local farmers. Once he became the blood-brother of a local chief, however, the people of the area agreed to sell Delamere his badly needed supplies.⁷⁵ Even the Maasai swore blood-brotherhood with British colonial officials before World War One.⁷⁶

Blood-brotherhood was more than just a social link which facilitated trade; it was a means to gain access to other resources as well. For example, the AGiriama maintain that if an Akamba settles with his AGiriama blood-brother on the AGiriama farm, the Akamba blood-brother could inherit the homestead and wives of his AGiriama blood-brother if there were no other real brothers available to inherit his property.⁷⁷ In Rabai, where the Christian missions

⁶⁹Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 97.

⁷⁰*Ibid.*, 129-131.

⁷¹Krapf, *Travels*, 116; McKay, "Precolonial History," 142.

⁷²Margery Perham, ed., *The Diaries of Lord Lugard* (London, 1959), I, 172-173, 269, 301.

⁷³C.C. von der Decken, *Reisen in Ost-Afrika*, ed. by Otto Kernsten (Leipzig, 1869), I, 248, cited in Merritt, "History of the Taita," 88.

⁷⁴Hobley, "A Visit to Tsavo and Taita," 549-550.

⁷⁵Elspeth Huxley, *White Man's Country: Lord Delamere and the Making of Kenya*, new ed. (London, 1980), I, 67.

⁷⁶*Ibid.*, II, 45. In 1918 the British government sent Kenyan African Rifle soldiers to collect Maasai youths for wartime service. In one recruitment drive two Maasai women were inadvertently killed, thereby abrogating the pact of blood-brotherhood between the British and the Maasai, sworn by their leader Legalishu years earlier.

⁷⁷Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 69, 91.

harbored fugitive and freed slaves who were known locally as the Ahendakudza (late-comers) or Nyasa people, the freed slaves and their descendants were able to acquire land on which to live and farm by becoming blood-brothers with the local ARavai people or by intermarriage.⁷⁸ AGiriama, ADuruma, and Akamba individuals also came to Rabai to live with their ARavai blood-brothers, were given land to farm, intermarried and when they died were buried on that land. Indeed, blood-brothers often would make their own daughters available for marriage to each other which would increase the kinship ties between themselves and their lineages.⁷⁹

One important reason why the ARavai were so successful in maintaining their role in regional and local commerce during the period of intense competition was that they utilized the institution of blood-brotherhood to sustain commercial bonds with their neighbors. An examination of the history of trading families in Rabai, Ruruma, Ribe, and Kambe territory indicates that those lineages which established and nurtured ties of blood-brotherhood were the most successful merchants in the palm wine trade and other commercial activity. Indeed, trade flourished in Rabai because the ARavai entrepreneurs living there were more intent upon creating socio-economic networks through blood-brotherhood than any of their counterparts in Ruruma, Ribe, or Kambe, as is evident from the chart here. Almost half of the families interviewed in Rabai who were involved in trade became blood-brothers with other Mijikenda traders as well as Akamba, Waata, and Taita merchants. On the other hand, the ARavai living in Ruruma demonstrated considerably less enthusiasm for blood-brotherhood. A few palm wine traders in Ruruma became nominal kin with AGiriama merchants, but there were no ties established with peoples living further inland. Apparently the more ambitious ARavai entrepreneurs gravitated towards Rabai where they would make contact with a more diverse group of traders, and there they could establish ties of blood-brotherhood. These bonds forged by the ARavai enabled them to compete successfully against Arab or Swahili long-distance caravan traders as well as against ARIhe and AKambe palm wine merchants.

Several of the most prominent ARavai traders owed their success to the multiple networks of kinship and commerce that they created by becoming blood-brothers with other businessmen. Nzaka Fondo of the Mkariaka clan in Rabai became blood-brother with some Taita hunters and this led to his success as an ivory trader during the mid-nineteenth century. Nzaka married a Taita woman and was given a Taita name, "Mburusi." Because he made so many journeys to and from Taita territory, his contemporaries joked that the Mkariaka clan originated in Taita land. On one of these trading expeditions Nzaka Fondo died and was buried in Taita land.⁸⁰ Kunya Nigogo, a cousin of Nzaka's and a member of the same Mkariaka clan of Rabai, conducted a lively trade with Akamba cattle herders, many of whom were his

⁷⁸Thomas J. Herlehy and Rodger F. Morton, "The Rise and Decline of Two Ex-Slave Communities in Coastal Kenya: The WaMisheni of Rabai and Ribe, 1880-1980," *The Suppression of Slavery in Africa*, ed. by Suzanne Miers and Igor Kopytoff (Madison, forthcoming), analyzes this phenomenon.

⁷⁹Herlehy, CPT 16: Madziwe Saha, CPT 43: Wesa Mwambawa.

⁸⁰Herlehy, CPT 4: Nzaka Kunya.

blood-brothers.⁸¹ Indeed, sales of palm wine to the Akamba by ARavai palm tree growers who swore blood-brotherhood with their Akamba business partners, enabled many ARavai farmers to accumulate their own herds of livestock. Saha Dzuya of the Mwajohadzuya clan, Mlangi Mtsunga and Washe Mlangi of the Tsui clan, Kavv Mulumbi of the Mkavvo clan, and Kailo wa Shehe of the Tiga clan in Rabai were some of the most renowned palm wine merchants in Rabai during the late nineteenth century. And by establishing ties of socio-economic cooperation with Akamba cattle herders, these palm wine merchants accumulated their own herds of livestock, becoming important cattle traders in Rabai, selling hides and beef even to Jomvu and Mom-basa.⁸² These ties were beneficial to the Taita, Waata, and Akamba as well. Taita and Waata hunters were extended credit by ARavai palm wine merchants, and they were guaranteed supplies of uchi and other palm products even during times of scarcity because of their bonds of blood-brotherhood with their ARavai friends. The Akamba used their relationships with the Mijikenda to gain access to pasture and farmland within the coastal region. When the Akamba migrated out of Ukambani in the early nineteenth century, and they settled around Mariakani, they were able to do so peacefully, largely because of the bonds of blood-brotherhood that existed between many local AGiriama and ARavai families with immigrant Akamba families.⁸³

Perhaps one of the most renowned, and successful merchants who utilized bonds of blood-brotherhood to build a lucrative commercial network throughout the coastal region was Kavv Mulumbi of Rabai. The life of Kavv is of special interest because it spans the period when Mijikenda local and regional traders experienced more intense competition from their counterparts throughout the coast. Kavv was born in Rabai some time in the 1830s, the son of an ARavai palm tree grower and an AChonyi woman, indicative of the intermarriage between Mijikenda peoples that would be a foundation of their sociopolitical unity. After his father died, Kavv's mother took him to her previous home in Chonyi territory, where Kavv was raised by his maternal uncles. From his maternal uncles Kavv learned how to grow and tap coconut palm trees for palm wine, indicative of the proliferation of coconut farming among the Mijikenda peoples. Kavv returned to Rabai upon his mother's death in order to claim his deceased father's coconut tree farms as his own. However, during his extended absence from Rabai, Kavv's paternal uncles had tended the family farm and they disputed Kavv's claim to the land and its coconut trees. Realizing that his opportunities were temporarily limited in Rabai because of the lack of support for his claims, Kavv Mulumbi mortgaged his trees to his paternal uncles as a means of settling, albeit temporarily, that dispute, and he invested the money received in goods such as jewelry, hardware, and blankets. Kavv joined an Arab caravan during the 1860s and for the next fifteen years he

⁸¹Herlehy, CPT 3: Figo Dzogofya, CPT 4: Nzaka Kunya, CPT 7: Nzaka Ngao, CPT 31: Shongwe Kombo, *kaya* elder (Ruruma) September 1980, and CPT 36: Tarazo Ndune, ex-sub Chief (Ruruma) September 1980.

⁸²Herlehy, CPT 5: Tsama Mkuzi, CPT 10: Ambari Washe, CPT 16: Madziwe Saha, CPT 15: Kailo Mzuka.

⁸³Krapf, *Travels and Labours*, 142-143; Cummings, "Aspects of Human Portage," 99-104; Spear, MHT 29: Kathungi Ndenge (AGiriama), MHT 33: Mitsanze Mwamure (AGiriama), MHT 35: Kimweli Mwandudu (Akamba), MHT 47: Mwavuo wa Menza (AGiriama).

engaged in the ivory trade. Kavú made several journeys on Arab and Swahili caravans, reportedly travelling as far as Buganda to purchase ivory.

After accumulating enough wealth from the ivory trade, Kavú returned to Rabai, and married his first wife, an ADigo woman, some time during the 1870s. Kavú settled on a family coconut farm that he redeemed from his paternal uncles. This farm was near the caravan route which passed through Rabai territory. From this location, Kavú continued to do business with merchants who travelled in the area, selling them and their associates foodstuffs and palm wine. In order to compete more effectively with rival traders Kavú became blood-brothers with several Akamba and ADuruma merchants. Kavú utilized these ties of kinship to accumulate livestock and enough bridewealth to marry a second wife, a local ARavai woman. With the help of his wives and the followers he was attracting because of his wealth, Kavú was able to establish four more coconut plantations within Rabai, and soon he was one of the busiest palm wine merchants in Rabai. Farmers in need of cash mortgaged their trees to him, and this enabled Kavú and his tappers to harvest and sell even more palm wine.

By the 1880s Kavú Mulumbi was one of the most influential entrepreneurs in Rabai. With his contacts ranging from AChonyi relatives in the north, to ADuruma and AKamba blood-brothers in the west, and ADigo in-laws to the south, Kavú was able to mobilize enough supporters to accumulate the foods and palm wine necessary to survive the series of famines which struck the coastal region during the 1880s and 1890s. Kavú maintained his preeminent position in Rabai as a businessman even after Rabai was brought under British colonial rule at the end of the nineteenth century. When the British stipulated that palm wine could be sold only from licensed clubs, Kavú became one of the first businessmen to build a club and pay the expensive fee required for a license from the colonial regime. During this time Kavú married a third wife, an AGiriama woman, and through her family he acquired more livestock and access to pasture land near Mariakani and Maji ya Chumvi. When Kavú died some time after World War I, he left his three sons a thriving palm wine business, four coconut farms, with mortgages on several others, several hundred cattle, and a network of business associates and blood-brothers unsurpassed in all of Rabai.⁸⁴

The ARihe and AKambe did not attach as much economic importance to blood-brotherhood as the ARavai did. The AKambe explain that they viewed blood-brotherhood more as a method to signify friendship and to prevent warfare, than as a means to create or strengthen trading relationships.⁸⁵ Still, a few enterprising ARihe and AKambe merchants did take advantage of the kinship ties implicit in blood-

⁸⁴The biographical sketch of Kavú Mulumbi is based upon testimony by his son, Dzuya Kavú, and other elders who knew of Kavú or were related to him, including Herlehy, CPT 3: Figo Dzogofya, CPT 4: Nzaka Kunya, CPT 21: Jindwa Karruku, *kaya* elder (Rabai) June 1980, CPT 26: Dzuya Kavú.

⁸⁵Herlehy, CPT 46: Ziro Mchombo and Chiringa Mwatela, *kaya* elders (Kambe) October 1980. Other Mijikenda people who took the same view of blood-brotherhood include Spear MHT 2: Mwinga wa Gunga (AGiriama), and MHT 38: Chimwenga wa Ndoro (ARihe).

brotherhood pacts to foster business ties with other traders. A prominent palm wine tapper in Ribe, Mgala Ndoro, moved westward towards Mariakani seeking opportunities there. Mgala met a local ARavai farmer near Mariakani, and settled with him on his farm as a business partner. After establishing his own coconut farm, Mgala travelled to Akamba herding grounds. Mgala swore blood-brotherhood with an Akamba cattle owner and from him Mgala bought livestock which he raised and sold back in Ribe. With the profits from this cattle trade Mgala established two more coconut farms in Ribe and invested in mortgages for several other estates.⁸⁶ Mwangongo Temo, a maize farmer in Kambe, travelled to Ukambani where he swore an oath of blood-brotherhood with a local herder. Mwangongo made several expeditions to Ukambani, buying cattle from his blood-brother and returning with them to sell in Kambe.⁸⁷ Most ARIhe bonds of blood-brotherhood were made with other Mijikenda farmers though, such as with the ADuruma, AChonyi, AJibana, and AGiriama. One ARIhe farmer became the blood-brother of an ARavai farmer in order to gain access to some fertile farmland on the Ribe-Ruruma border. Dzomba Munga of Ribe settled with Masuzi Tsopika of Ruruma, working with him as a tapper and trader of palm wine.⁸⁸ Another ARIhe farmer, Mwangiri Kopa, pledged blood-brotherhood with a Swahili merchant, Shaban bin Salim, thereby gaining favorable access to the commercial networks of Mombasa.⁸⁹

The bonds of blood-brotherhood and the strength of the ARavai palm wine trade were most evident during the food crises which challenged all the Mijikenda during the mid and late nineteenth century. Famine struck the Kenya coast four times between 1880 and 1900 and yet even though Rabai was a food importing and palm wine exporting locale, the people there experienced less dislocation from the food shortages than did other parts of the coast. The strong demand for palm wine, both for ritual and daily use, even during times of famine, ensured that some food was brought to Rabai where it was traded for wine. In this way palm growers acquired foodstuffs. Those farmers whose trees suffered from drought sought refuge with kin, including blood brothers, throughout the coastal region. And by calling upon those ties of blood-brotherhood, many families received the sustenance necessary to survive the famines of that time.⁹⁰

Another social institution which helped to create unity within the coastal region was *utani*, the joking relationship. Although it is more common in Tanzania, *utani* was another way for some peoples

⁸⁶Herlehy, CPT 44: Mulinge Mgala.

⁸⁷Herlehy, CPT 45: Daniel Katana, store owner (Kambe) October 1980.

⁸⁸Herlehy, CPT 44: Chireri Dzomba, farmer (Ribe) October 1980.

⁸⁹Herlehy, CPT 47: Chai Munga, *kaya* elder (Ribe) November 1980.

⁹⁰Concerning the importance of blood-brotherhood and the palm wine trade during times of famine, see Thomas J. Herlehy, "An Economic History of the Food Crisis in Africa: Surviving Famines Along the Kenya Coast, ca. 1800-1980," a paper presented to the African Studies Association annual meeting, 8 December 1983, to be printed in the Boston University African Studies Center Working Paper Series (forthcoming).

in Kenya to form amicable relationships.⁹¹ Utani has a similar origin as blood-brotherhood in that it is a method used to institutionalize good relations between people who may have been traditional enemies. When two people have an utani relationship, it signifies that they will accept as jokes remarks which they might have taken as insults in the past. Within the Kenyan coastal region the Vumba and Digo shared a joking relationship.⁹² Further inland, the Taita and Akamba also used utani to forge unity between themselves.⁹³ Both of these groups of people were trading partners as well as potential rivals for trade but utani helped to diffuse situations of potential aggression and enabled these peoples to cooperate with each other to their mutual benefit.

Intermarriage was another very common method used to foster social unity in Kenya and throughout Africa in the nineteenth century. Although estimates of the amount of intermarriage which took place among the peoples of the coastal region are extremely difficult to find, if one uses collective biographies of local lineages, some patterns do begin to emerge. Certainly among the Mijikenda themselves there was quite a bit of intermarriage. Trading partners and neighbors tended to intermarry quite a bit, and it is for this reason that the ARavai, ADuruma, and AGiriama intermarried more with each other than with the other Mijikenda, for example, the AJibana or AKambe. Workers who immigrated to new locales often intermarried with the people among whom they came to work. ADigo and AGiriama blacksmiths who came to Rabai to make and sell tappers' knives intermarried with local women during the nineteenth century.⁹⁴ Marriage patterns like this helped to forge the social unity which the Mijikenda enjoyed for much of the nineteenth century.

There was intermarriage between the Mijikenda and their neighbors, the Swahili, Waata, Taita, and Akamba, too. According to local traditions, many Mijikenda sub-clans trace their origins back to these inter-ethnic marriages.⁹⁵ For example, in Rabai, the Mwamkamba sub-clan was formed when the ARavai intermarried with Akamba immigrants near the coast. One of the most famous founders of the Mwamkamba sub-clan was Mwinga, an ARavai ivory trader who traveled back and forth between Ukambani and Rabai. Mwinga married the daughters of several of his Akamba trading partners and they were among the progenitors of the new sub-clan.⁹⁶

Islam was another institutional link which helped to bind the peoples within the coast together, although more research needs to be done concerning precisely why some groups, among the Mijikenda for example, tended to convert to Islam while others did not. Trade

⁹¹Regarding *utani* in Tanzania, see R.E. Moreau, "The Joking Relationship (*Utani*) in Tanganyika," *Tanganyika Notes and Records*, XII (December, 1941), 1-9.

⁹²McKay, "Precolonial History," 133-135.

⁹³Merritt, "History of the Taita," 151.

⁹⁴Testimony of Daba wa Karisa (Rabai) and Nzaka Kunya (Rabai), 1970, collected by R.F. Morton, transcripts available at Syracuse University Library; Herlehy, CPT 7: Nzaka Ngao, CPT 9: Kola Mruu, village elder (Rabai) April, 1980.

⁹⁵Spear, *The Kaya Complex*, 50-51.

⁹⁶Testimony of Nzaka Kunya (Rabai) and Tugow Mwabaya (Rabai), 1970, R.F. Morton collection.

between the Muslims of the coast and their Mijikenda neighbors often was accompanied by Swahili or Arab efforts to convert their local contacts.⁹⁷ Some Muslims from the coast even settled among the Mijikenda as farmers and proselytized from within the midst of the Mijikenda.⁹⁸ Islam was an attractive alternative for some individuals because Muslims were reputed to have very powerful medicines which could cure many illnesses.⁹⁹

Although some people did convert to Islam during the nineteenth century, there were not very many Muslims within the coastal region, beyond the coast itself, by 1900. Those Mijikenda who did convert to Islam were known as *mahaji* and they usually settled around coastal towns where other Muslims lived. The ADigo began to convert to Islam in the early nineteenth century and by the end of the century they were the most Islamicized of all the Mijikenda peoples. Some of the AJibana converted to Islam as well. A few AKauma who lived near Mtanganyiko became Muslims, too.¹⁰⁰ Muslim traders from the coast penetrated as far as Ukambani and beyond during this period, but they enjoyed less success proselytizing there than nearer the coast. Still, conversions were made. For example, one ARavai trader who went to Kitui to buy cattle in the late nineteenth century met an Arab trader there and was converted to Islam by the Muslim merchant.¹⁰¹

Conclusion

The Kenyan coastal area formed a relatively unified socioeconomic region by about 1900. The economic basis of this cohesion was the interdependence of the economic specialists who lived within the different parts of the coastal area. By trading their own locally produced goods, the Swahili, Arabs, Mijikenda, Orma, Waata, Taita, and Akamba created extensive local networks which acted as ties that bound them and their economic systems together. For example, palm wine was one of the most popular commodities which was produced and consumed within the coastal region. The demand for uchi prompted the Mijikenda to adopt coconut palm cultivation and the ARavai eventually emerged as the most prominent palm wine tappers and traders within the coastal region during the nineteenth and even the twentieth century. But uchi also circulated throughout the coastal region along the networks of exchange which linked the peoples of the area together. Indeed, it was the strong demand for locally produced goods like palm wine which kept the peoples of the coast in constant contact with each other, binding them into a cohesive regional unit.

⁹⁷A.H.J. Prins, *The Coastal Tribes of the North-Eastern Bantu* (London, 1952), 37-38; Krapf, *Travels*, 138-139.

⁹⁸Herlehy, CPT 11: Dagamra Shaha, CPT 37: Uthman Kinda.

⁹⁹David J. Parkin, "Medicines and Men of Influence," *Man*, 3, 3 (1968), 424-439.

¹⁰⁰F.F. Morton, "Slaves, Fugitives and Freedmen on the Kenya Coast" (Ph.D. thesis, Syracuse University, 1976), 346; Berg, "Mombasa Under the Busaidi," 88-89; J. Spencer Trimingham, *Islam in East Africa* (Oxford, 1964), 38-39, 52-53, 68-70, 112-125; Koffsky, "Takaungu," 111-113.

¹⁰¹Herlehy, CPT 13: Bemunga Abdallah's father, Mutta Mwakoyo, converted to Islam in Kitui and thereafter was known as Abdallah bin Abdallah, taking the name of his own Muslim teacher.

The social basis of the unity of the Kenya coast was the active participation of the inhabitants in rituals and institutions which created cross-ethnic links among them, especially in those which created nominal and real kinship ties. One of the most widely used methods to foster inter-ethnic cooperation was through the pledging of blood-brotherhood. By becoming blood-brothers, individuals committed themselves and their families to close cooperation with people who would otherwise be strangers in their communities. Utani was another method used to integrate peoples who may have been combatants or rivals at one time or another. Intermarriage with someone from outside one's own ethnic group created kinship links as well. The spread of Islam and the gradual adoption of many aspects of Swahili culture, including language, dress and manners, provided another important cross-ethnic link within the coastal region.

The existence of these fairly strong and widespread ties among the peoples of the coast suggests that this region was already well on its way to becoming a functional and cohesive unit long before the establishment of British colonial rule brought nominal political unity to this part of East Africa. Traders were already able to travel long distances in relative safety to buy and sell goods not available within their own domestic economy. People migrated to live in different parts of the coast, searching for better opportunities to earn a living. Individuals became members of separate clans and ethnic groups, other than the ones into which they had been born, and this served as the basis of a nascent regional identity. The trade in palm wine and the pledge of blood-brotherhood were two of the strongest mechanisms for integrating the separate peoples and economic zones of the coast into a well-structured sphere of action. These were the ties that bound the coastal region together during the nineteenth century.